Social Enterprises and the SDGs: Contributions to Quality Education, Climate Action, and Inclusive Growth

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ABSTRACT

Social enterprises hold a remarkable space in the development scenery: they necessitate to endure as businesses while held responsible to a social or environmental operations — which is precisely the variety of dual capacity the UN Sustainable Development Goals. This study strives to know the contribution of social enterprises in India towards three goals: Quality Education (SDG 4), Climate Action (SDG 13), and finally Inclusive Growth (SDG 8 and SDG 10 collectively). It draws on a survey of 412 social enterprises across six sectors, supplemented by interviews and a handful of illustrative case vignettes. Respondents rated their own organisation's contribution to each goal on a five-point scale, and we used multiple regression to work out which organisational features actually predict stronger inclusive-growth outcomes. The pattern that emerged was fairly consistent: enterprises scored themselves highest on inclusive growth (M = 4.05, SD = 0.62), a little lower on quality education (M = 3.92, SD = 0.68), and noticeably lower on climate action (M = 3.54, SD = 0.81). What predicted inclusive growth wasn't how long an enterprise had been running — age came out non-significant — but how embedded it was in its community, along with its access to funding and its level of digital adoption. Enterprises working in women's livelihoods and agriculture reported the strongest inclusive-growth scores of any sector. Together, these results suggest social enterprises act as useful intermediaries that translate the SDGs into locally workable action, though their climate contribution still lags well behind their social and

economic one. We close with some practical suggestions for strengthening the ecosystem that supports SDG-aligned social enterprises.

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